

DRUG-PREP

RECOMMENDATIONS AND BEST PRACTICES FOR NATIONAL IMPLEMENTATION OF FORESIGHT STRATEGIES



Title: Deliverable 3.5: Recommendations and best practices for national implementation of foresight strategies

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RECOMMENDATIONS FOR HORIZON SCANNING IN THE DRUGS FIELD

Overarching process

1. Clearly define the **purpose** of your exercise.
2. Clearly specify your **scope** and make a framework of the topic you are studying.
3. Allocate sufficient **time and resources** to the preparatory stage.
4. Be **transparent** and justify methodological choices made.
5. Involve **experts from various domains** – also outside the drugs field – from an early stage of the preparations to shape the project and create shared ownership.
6. Be aware that foresight research is most valid as an **iterative process**. Validate and revisit findings throughout the process.

Literature review to identify trends

1. While foresight inherently deals with uncertainties, a **solid scientific background** is essential to conduct literature reviews and use mixed-method approaches.
2. Facilitate regular **mutual training sessions** for the research team.
3. Schedule regular **'peer-to-peer' moments** with the project team members to go over findings and address uncertainties.
4. **Build on existing knowledge**. Integrate findings from reports outlining trends and previous foresight exercises.
5. Consider how **tools** (such as digital or artificial intelligence supported tools) can facilitate information analysis.
6. Do not underestimate the importance of a **360° approach** across all STEEP fields. Ignoring an angle can have major implications on the quality and future-proof value of your results.



Expert validation of trends

1. We cannot emphasise enough the importance of expert engagement. Make sure that subject experts validate the trends identified.
2. Maintain channels of communication with the experts at different stages to make sure they are engaged throughout the project (e.g., consider establishing a community of practice).
3. During an expert validation workshop, create an atmosphere that encourages participants to bring in their own expertise and to challenge what is put forward. Make sure to have a trained moderator leading the workshop and allow sufficient time for meaningful discussion.
4. Digital/online tools can make a workshop more powerful as they facilitate ranking exercises and allow a systematic way of collecting information from participants, ensuring all voices are heard.



INTRODUCTION

The DRUG-PREP project aimed to contribute to greater preparedness and resilience of drug information systems in Europe by piloting the use of foresight approaches, specifically horizon scanning, in the drugs field at the national level. This is in line with the EU Drugs Strategy 2021–2025, which underscores the importance of building foresight capacities to enable innovative and agile responses to the growing complexity of drug-related issues, as well as to enhance the preparedness of the EU and its Member States to respond to future challenges and crises (Council of the European Union, 2021). Foresight generates insights about the medium- to long-term future and is a powerful tool for informing present decisions and fostering collective action. Horizon scanning, an approach under the umbrella of foresight methods, collects signals about current or imminent changes as well as potential indications of new emerging issues (European Foresight Platform, n.d.).

Between 2022 and 2024, the partners in DRUG-PREP carried out horizon scanning exercises to identify and validate trends and megatrends that may affect the future drugs situation in the six countries involved in the project: Belgium, Czechia, Finland, Ireland, the Netherlands, and Portugal. Horizon scanning, and foresight in general, is inherently exploratory, requiring participants to think creatively and embrace uncertainties. This can be at odds with traditional research approaches that often avoid ambiguity. For the partners involved, DRUG-PREP offered a unique learning opportunity to engage with these methods and develop new capacities. An intangible outcome of the DRUG-PREP project is the mutual learning process and identification of barriers and facilitators for national drug information systems when conducting and implementing foresight actions.

This document reflects on the lessons learnt from the horizon scanning exercises carried out in DRUG-PREP. For further details on the methodological approach used in the project, readers can refer to the companion report, ‘Summary report on country-specific insights based on Horizon Scanning’ (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2025a). That report outlines the methodology for horizon scanning used by the different countries, highlights key differences in methodology used, and compiles key trends and country-specific insights on their implications.

In light of the clear added value of conducting such exercises at national level, the DRUG-PREP project aims to provide tips and tricks for horizon scanning and encourage other researchers or practitioners to initiate their journey into futures-based approaches. The recommendations are based on the inputs from DRUG-PREP partners in a survey and focus group (see Annex for more details on the methodology).



***How to read this document:** This document starts with recommendations regarding the overarching process of horizon scanning. It then provides recommendations related to the first step in a horizon scanning exercise, a literature review to identify trends and megatrends, followed by recommendations on conducting expert validation of identified trends through workshops. Each sub-section of this report starts by outlining the recommendations for that step, followed by elaboration on the lessons learnt from DRUG-PREP.*

RECOMMENDATIONS

Overarching process



1. Clearly define the **purpose** of your exercise.
2. Clearly specify your **scope** and make a framework of the topic you are studying.
3. Allocate sufficient **time and resources** to the preparatory stage.
4. Be **transparent** and justify methodological choices made.
5. Involve **experts from various domains** – also outside the drugs field – from an early stage of the preparations to shape the project and create shared ownership.
6. Be aware that foresight research is most valid as an **iterative process**. Validate and revisit findings throughout the process.

Foresight allows flexibility in the methods to be used, with a variety of methods available, of which horizon scanning is one. The specific methodology to be chosen depends on factors such as the research question, topic, project funding, specific call, expectations, and the researchers' capabilities. When communicating on the work done, as with any research approach, it is important to justify and be transparent on the methodological choices made. Given that foresight inherently deals with uncertainties and hypotheses, transparency is particularly important to ensure reproducibility and credibility of the findings.

A common step-by-step plan was developed in DRUG-PREP for horizon scanning, which included a literature review, trend description and a validation workshop. One of the main difficulties faced by the researchers was the fact that certain STEEP fields or topics are outside their area of expertise (e.g., advanced technological topics), sometimes leading to avoidance of complex or novel topics. Venturing outside the drugs field – the researchers' field of expertise – was not always easy. This underlines the importance of involving people with different expertise from the beginning of the horizon scanning process or even prior to the project development to ensure their buy-in. It is important to never underestimate that the 360° approach is crucial in foresight. As in all qualitative research approaches, how you feed an exercise has important consequences on the outcome. Given the complex and multi-faceted nature of the drugs phenomenon, a multi-disciplinary approach cannot be underestimated. Researchers investing in foresight must be aware that the preparatory stage is critical and can be time-consuming, including identifying partners and external experts with appropriate expertise, defining the methodology, incorporating peer-to-peer support, and defining a concrete objective and application for the exercise. Investing in this preparatory phase is critical for a successful foresight exercise.

Another key learning from DRUG-PREP was the importance of properly framing the research question prior to starting a foresight exercise, defining the scope, focus, and direction of the project. A well-defined research question ensures that participants know the objectives of the project and increases the chances to achieve tangible results (e.g., actionable insights) and intangible benefits. Without a clear and specific question, the process can become unfocused, leading to fragmented outcomes and reduced engagement. The DRUG-PREP project addressed a broad and overarching question about the trends and megatrends shaping the future of drugs. While this allowed for wide exploration, some partners encountered challenges in maintaining focus and extracting practical insights. This highlights the importance of defining a scope that balances specificity and ambition.

Finally, it is important to see that foresight is an iterative process. It is important to validate and revisit the findings throughout the process both internally within the core research team and externally with experts inside and outside the drugs field.

Literature review to identify trends

1. While foresight inherently deals with uncertainties, a **solid scientific background** is essential to conduct literature reviews and use mixed-method approaches.
2. Facilitate regular **mutual training sessions** for the research team to build a **shared understanding and sense of ownership** of the methodology.
3. Schedule regular **‘peer-to-peer’ moments** with the project team members to go over findings and address uncertainties. Formalise these sessions as part of standard protocols (rather than relying on ad hoc intentions) to sustain collaboration throughout the process.
4. **Build on existing knowledge.** Integrate findings from reports outlining trends and previous foresight exercises, regardless of the domain. This creates a strong foundation for your foresight process.
5. Horizon scanning implies the analysis of large amounts of information. Consider how **tools** (such as digital or artificial intelligence supported tools) can facilitate information analysis.
6. Do not underestimate the importance of a **360° approach** across all STEEP fields. Ignoring an angle can have major implications on the quality and future-proof value of your results.



Horizon scanning generally starts with a literature review to identify trends across the different STEEP-fields. Challenges highlighted by the DRUG-PREP partners included the seemingly endless nature of the exercise and uncertainties about when the literature review could be considered sufficiently comprehensive, given the wide scope of the project. Partners also faced challenges in selecting relevant and robust sources that include future-oriented findings. For example, they questioned whether to include grey literature that offered valuable insights into trends but lacked the methodological rigour of scientific publications. Therefore, partners approached the literature review differently (e.g., including scientific literature, grey literature or a combination of both). The DRUG-PREP project team identified several recommendations to address this difficulty.

First, in-depth training on the general principles of foresight is essential, including a detailed introduction to horizon scanning methodology. This should include hands-on practice and guidance on selecting, developing and applying the methodology. Such a training not only fosters a strong sense of ownership on the approach, but also creates a supportive peer-to-peer environment. This allows researchers to openly discuss and address barriers, and empowers them to deal with uncertainties. This is crucial as science and uncertainties are generally considered to be at odds with each other. However, embracing uncertainty is a core feature of foresight research. All actors involved must be convinced of this unique characteristic of the foresight approach, and be equipped with the skills to handle and make the most of uncertainty.

The DRUG-PREP consortium partners noted the need for a step-by-step guide to support researchers carrying out a literature review and trend analysis in horizon scanning, especially when applying it to a specific domain such as the drugs field. This should include guidance on how to handle global megatrends that may also have a relevant impact to the national level. In response to this need, a handbook was developed to provide practical advice to the researchers (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2023). Furthermore, foresight studies require a skilled multi-disciplinary research team, including experts in qualitative and quantitative research. Researchers experienced in systematic literature reviews and thematic qualitative analysis proved invaluable in the literature review process.

Another key challenge in horizon scanning is organising, structuring and prioritising a long list of identified trends, which entails analysis of a large amount of information. Some of the DRUG-PREP partners suggested a ‘counting exercise’, as outlined in the foresight toolkit to support this process. However, this technique is a supplementary tool rather than a definitive approach. While helpful, it does not carry the same methodological rigor or value as systematic reviews or comprehensive national foresight reports. Horizon scanning requires synthesising large amounts of information from many different sources, which can be difficult for individual researchers or research teams. This highlights an opportunity to explore the use of tools to support the analysis of large amounts of information, such as artificial intelligence supported tools or dashboards for horizon scanning.

The level of focus of the trends identified across countries sometimes differed: megatrends, national trends, drug-specific trends. Some countries opted to focus on specific STEEP fields only, due to the expertise of the involved researchers or due to time and resource constraints. While these decisions may be justified, foresight research is only successful when approached with a 360° mindset, identifying different trends and exploring their connections.

Ultimately, horizon scanning was viewed as a ‘learning by doing’ process. Peer-to-peer review sessions emerged as a particularly effective means of addressing challenges encountered during the literature review and broader horizon scanning activities. Sharing experiences and learning collaboratively was a powerful tool for overcoming obstacles and enhancing the process.



Expert validation of trends

1. We cannot emphasise enough the importance of expert engagement. Make sure that subject experts validate the trends identified.
2. Maintain channels of communication with the experts at different stages to make sure they are engaged throughout the project (e.g., consider establishing a community of practice).
3. During an expert validation workshop, create an atmosphere that encourages participants to bring in their own expertise and to challenge what is put forward. Make sure to have a trained moderator leading the workshop and allow sufficient time for meaningful discussion.
4. Digital/online tools can make a workshop more powerful as they facilitate ranking exercises and allow a systematic way of collecting information from participants, ensuring all voices are heard.

Foresight research is by definition participatory, requiring input from a variety of stakeholders. The question of when and how to engage stakeholders is often raised, in recognition of not wanting to overburden stakeholders, especially in a domain where the pool of experts is relatively small. Some DRUG-PREP partners opted to only involve experts within their organisation, while others involved external experts. Trends often have cross-domain and intersectional impacts. Engaging experts with diverse expertise helps to explore those broader implications and achieve a more well-rounded understanding of the trends and their trickle down effects. This is particularly important for foresight in the drugs field, which is highly influenced by many different fields and should not be viewed from one side only. The choice of which experts to involve should be guided by the project's objectives and required input, with different options for expert involvement being entirely valid if they are line with the objectives.

It can be difficult to engage experts (in particular those who are not related to the drugs field), especially given the time-consuming and complex nature of foresight and horizon scanning. When engaging experts in the foresight process, it is important to clearly explain the expected outcomes of the project and underline the shared benefits. For example, a clear benefit of involvement in a foresight workshop is the networking opportunity (meeting and discussing with stakeholders relevant to their work), which should be highlighted when inviting experts. It can be easier to engage external stakeholders if the objectives of the exercise are clearly defined and tangible (e.g., leading to policy recommendations for external exercises, organisational recommendations for internal exercises), especially if these are linked to a specific stage in the policy cycle or organisational strategy.

The question of what groups of experts to include was a key discussion raised by the DRUG-PREP partners, in particular whether to include decision makers, people who use drugs or people with lived experience, in order to overcome potential bias in expert panels. It is important to be aware that any group brings its own set of biases and values to the process.

Overall, the decision on who to invite to a validation workshop depends on your expected outcomes. This underlines the importance of clearly defining the purpose of the foresight exercise in advance, as mentioned in section A above.

A valuable approach to ensure sustainability of the foresight project is to set up a 'community of practice', a group of stakeholders with an active interest in foresight who are willing to be involved in the exercises. This allows longitudinal involvement of motivated experts over several foresight activities. The added benefit of such an approach is that it ensures commitment from stakeholders who have expressed interest. For example, throughout the DRUG-PREP project, materials were added to the EUDA's PLATO platform to share the project's learnings to a network of professionals in the drugs field from across Europe. The value of this platform is its sustainable nature and ability to reach a wider audience outside the project's immediate network. Additionally, a community of practice was established by the Irish partner by bringing together a small group of engaged stakeholders in the various foresight exercises at national level.

In all circumstances, time is crucial. Sufficient time must be invested towards the organisation of a foresight workshop, to introduce participants to the foresight approach and to conduct the validation process, especially in early stages of foresight when participants are less familiar with the approach. To get the most insights, it is vital to create an atmosphere that encourages participants to bring in their own expertise. For instance, focus group methods such as Nominal Group Technique (a structured variation of brainstorming that starts with individual idea generation followed by systematic sharing of ideas in group discussion) can be useful to ensure that each participant has a chance to share their thoughts. It is also useful to actively ask whether certain trends are missing or use an online voting tool (see last paragraph of this section) in order to involve every participant in the process. Participants should feel that they have the space and opportunity to challenge what is put forward.

Most partners carried out a ranking exercise during expert validation workshops, in which each trend was ranked in terms of its impact on the drugs field and the extent to which it is already addressed. The objective of this exercise was to identify 'priority' trends: those ranked as high impact but insufficiently addressed. Participants new to foresight sometimes found this exercise challenging, particularly when asked to evaluate trends outside their usual area of expertise. Participants also found it difficult to rank a trend in terms of its impact without first considering the implications of that trend on the drugs field. To facilitate the ranking exercise, some DRUG-PREP partners found it preferable to first guide participants through a discussion of the implications of the STEEP trends on the drugs field. This helped participants to better understand and evaluate the trends, providing information to support the subsequent ranking exercise. The use of preliminary trend cards including a description of the trend and some possible implications on the drugs field also helped to make the trends more 'snackable' to use during the trend

validation workshops and provided a starting point for discussions (e.g., EUDA trend cards).

Some DRUG-PREP partners opted to send preparatory work in advance to the experts (e.g., asking participants to rank the trends by completing a survey), in order to select a small number of prioritised trends to focus on during the workshop. This is only possible when experts are already sufficiently introduced to the foresight approach and the planned exercise (e.g., in the case of a 'community of practice', see above). Another way to facilitate the ranking of trends was to implement an online voting tool (e.g., Mentimeter, Slido, Wooclap,...) during the validation workshop, to ensure the vote of each participant carried the same weight.

CONCLUSION

This document presents recommendations to consider when initiating and conducting foresight exercises on the national level in the drugs field. While foresight research allows for many methodological options, the recommendations in this document refer mainly to the practicalities of horizon scanning. DRUG-PREP was a learning experience for all the researchers involved. While there was a step-by-step plan proposed in the manual ‘How to do trend analysis: A foresight toolkit by DRUG-PREP for the drugs field’ (DRUG-PREP consortium, 2023), methodological differences were observed. This provides lessons learnt from the different national experiences and choices, and a starting point for in-depth discussion on the uncertainties in protocol development and execution of foresight.

Overall, the participatory approach is crucial. A wide range of experts should be involved, both inside and outside the drugs field, from an early stage of the project. Participants need to be sufficiently introduced to the foresight approach. ‘Futures literacy’ and comfort in dealing with uncertainties is sometimes difficult to achieve, as priority is often given to current issues. Including the same group of experts throughout, or establishing a ‘community of practice’, can strengthen the activities. When engaging experts, it is important to underline that foresight is a tool to help policymaking, rather than a goal in itself.

The networking aspect is highly valuable in foresight, bringing together actors from different areas of the drugs field who may not have other similar forums for interaction, depending on the country’s organisation. Moreover, exploring the drugs phenomenon from different angles is a key objective and major added value. When engaging experts, it is important to explain the objectives of the project, which can include for example internal capacity building, contributing to an organisational strategy, or providing policy recommendations. Highlighting shared benefits can facilitate expert involvement.

This links to the importance of having a clear objective of the project, with a well-defined research question. Investing sufficient time in preparatory work and having a clear focus and direction facilitates stakeholder engagement and increases chances of valuable results. A vague or overly ambitious project without appropriate resources or timeline can lead to less engagement or less valuable insights.

Finally, foresight is most powerful when carried out iteratively. It is important to validate and revisit the findings throughout the process. Foresight exercises should not be seen as a one-time exercise, but should be repeated at intervals in time (e.g., at fixed points in the policy cycle for policy-oriented foresight projects), revisiting findings and taking into account new trends and signals of change. The DRUG-PREP project confirmed the value of conducting horizon scanning at different levels (European, national, but even at the regional or local level) and highlighted how trends evolve dynamically. This approach enables a more nuanced understanding of trends and identification of convergence across contexts.

DRUG-PREP was an important step in installing a future-oriented thinking in the national drug policy context, and should be followed up with concrete steps including further capacity building to install foresight as a building block in sustainable drug monitoring and response systems. Future actions should address the remaining knowledge gaps, for example how to detect and deal with subtle signals of change, or how to support the analysis of large amounts of information in horizon scanning.

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ANNEX

Methodology used to develop this report

A two-step methodology was used to collect feedback from the consortium members on their experience carrying out horizon scanning. Firstly, a survey was sent to all DRUG-PREP partners. This was followed up by a focus group which allowed for more in-depth interaction on the experiences in a group discussion.

A. Survey

An open-ended survey was sent to the DRUG-PREP partners to collect their insights and experiences from carrying out horizon scanning and expert validation of trends. The survey was shared via LimeSurvey and included the following eight open-ended questions:

1. What is the current status of your foresight research? What have you been able to do so far, and what should you still conduct or plan ahead?
2. Please try to explain the method that you have applied for conducting the horizon scanning. If you had to set up a step-by-step plan, what would it look like?
3. Are there specific choices you have made for implementing/conducting the horizon scanning? Please also explain why you decided on those options.
4. Have you stumbled upon certain difficulties during this work? Please explain why it was experienced as such, and elaborate on elements that have helped you in overcoming any obstacles.
5. What are you still struggling with that you have not found a solution for so far?
6. If you were to look back at the past year and a half, what would have been a gamechanger for you? Knowing what you know now, what do you wish that you knew earlier? What would have helped you?
7. If someone were to approach you and ask for advice on horizon scanning or futures concepts as a whole, what tips or tricks would you share with that person?
8. Have you already organised and conducted any expert groups / workshops¹? If so, who did you invite? Which profile? What was your approach? And what was your first impression of it?

As a first step, the results of the survey were synthesised in order to guide the focus group discussion.

¹ Expert workshops were an agreed part of the methodology used in DRUG-PREP. The aim of expert workshops was to validate and elaborate on the trends identified through the initial stages of horizon scanning.

B. Focus group discussion

On 4 December 2023, a full-day DRUG-PREP consortium meeting was organised on the side-lines of the European Harm Reduction Conference in Budapest, Hungary. Within the consortium meeting, a focus group discussion was organised to allow the partners to discuss their experience in applying and implementing future-oriented methods at the national level, and explore the barriers they faced. The objective of the workshop was to define barriers, lessons learnt, and tips and tricks on conducting foresight research at the national level.

The focus group was structured as follows:

1. Tour de table: each partner presented a state-of-play of the foresight research in their country, focusing on the current status of their work, what had already been done, and what still needed to be done or planned
2. Results of the survey (see above): the responses of the survey that had been received at that point were presented to the group
3. Group discussion: the primary focus was to further elaborate the outcomes of the survey and collect additional feedback from the consortium members on their experience with foresight research